

The Space, The Script, The Performer: Performance as a Way of Life

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Abstract

This study interrogates The Space, The Script, The Performer: Performance as a Way of Life by examining how these three pillars define both artistic practice and lived experience. The central problem addressed is the tendency to reduce performance to staged entertainment, overlooking its role as a cultural, social, and existential practice. The objective of the study is to demonstrate how space, script, and performer extend beyond theatrical boundaries to shape human behaviour, social relations, and identity formation. Methodologically, the paper employs a qualitative approach, drawing from textual analysis, ethnographic observations, and reflective critique of performance practices in theatre and everyday life. The theoretical framework is rooted in performance studies (Schechner), phenomenology of lived experience (Merleau-Ponty), and the anthropological insights of ritual and cultural performance (Turner). Conceptually, the study situates performance as both an artistic act and a life practice, emphasizing its recursive relationship with society. Findings reveal that performance, when understood as a way of life, dissolves the strict divide between art and existence, positioning human beings as perpetual performers negotiating meaning, identity, and transformation. This reframing enriches both theatre scholarship and cultural discourse by foregrounding performance as a universal human condition.

Keywords: Performance, Space, Script, Performer, Cultural Identity

Introduction

Performance studies have increasingly recognized that theatre, ritual, and enactment are **not confined to the stage** but permeate social life, urban spaces, and digital interactions (Schechner, 2020; Fischer-Lichte, 2008). Yet much of the literature remains fragmented: spatial analyses often reside in architecture or urban studies, script analyses in literary or dramaturgical traditions, and performer studies in acting pedagogy or identity theory. This siloed scholarship limits understanding of **performance as an interdependent system** in which space, script, and performer mutually shape meaning.

To address this gap, the present study proposes an **ecological model of performance**. Performance is reconceived not as a bounded artistic event but as **a living, adaptive way of life**, extending across proscenium stages, community gatherings, urban streets, and digital platforms. Within this framework, space functions as both a physical and symbolic environment; scripts emerge from written texts, oral traditions, cultural repertoires, and technological affordances; and performers—professional or everyday participants—act as agents of negotiation, continuously shaping and reshaping identity through inventive enactments. This model foregrounds **African performance traditions**, including Soyinka's fourth stage, Ukala's folkism, Afroskenology, and Mda's applied theatre, as conceptually generative rather than illustrative, demonstrating that hybrid, site-sensitive, and community-engaged practices can inform global performance theory (Amonyenze, 2023; Kerr, 2019; Mhlambi, 2019). Digital environments are similarly positioned as **performative ecologies**, revealing both creative potential and infrastructural inequalities (Soto-Sanfiel, Freeman, & Angulo-Brunet, 2022; Verma, 2019).

Despite increasing recognition of performance as a socially embedded and hybrid phenomenon, scholarship often analyzes **space, script, and performer in isolation**, confined to disciplinary silos: spatial studies in architecture and urban theory, script analyses in literary or dramaturgical traditions, and performer-centered studies in acting pedagogy or identity research. This fragmentation constrains understanding of **performance as an ecological system**, particularly in African and digitally mediated contexts, where improvisation, communal engagement, and technological affordances shape dynamic enactments. Moreover, Eurocentric paradigms dominate performance theory, frequently marginalizing **African epistemologies, oral traditions, and site-specific practices**, which offer unique insights into performance as a way of life. Digital platforms, too, are often treated as distribution channels rather than performative ecologies, obscuring questions of access, inequality, and co-creative potential (Tacchi, 2000; Hendy, 2020).

In response, this study proposes an **original ecological model of performance** that foregrounds African and digital practices as central, demonstrating how **space, script, and performer interrelate to sustain performance as a lived, adaptive system**. Guided by this aim, the study addresses four interrelated research questions: (1) How do space, script, and performer interact ecologically to shape performance in African and digital contexts? (2) In what

ways do African performance traditions—such as Soyinka's fourth stage, Ukala's folkism, Afrosceology, and Mda's applied theatre—contribute to theorizing performance beyond Eurocentric paradigms? (3) How can performance training and design incorporate the ecological interdependence of space, script, and performer in both physical and digital environments? (4) What insights does the ecological model offer for understanding digital inequality and inclusive audience participation in contemporary performance? By situating **African and digital practices at the center of performance theory**, this study advances a framework that is simultaneously theoretical, methodological, and practical. The ecological model encourages **plural, practice-sensitive research approaches**, integrating ethnography, phenomenology, and technical analysis to capture the hybrid, embodied, and tacit dimensions of performance (Freshwater, 2017; McEnery & Xiao, 2020; Reason & Lindelof, 2016). Ultimately, conceiving performance as an ecological system affirms its role as a **persistent, participatory, and culturally resilient practice**, capable of sustaining identity, social cohesion, and creative innovation across local and global contexts.

Methodologically, this research uses qualitative fieldwork in Nigeria (Lagos and potentially other urban centers), combining observation of performances in varied spatial settings (open-air, site-specific, theatre spaces, digital streams), interviews with performers, directors, audience members, and analyses of scripts both formal and tacit. Practice-led and embodied observation will be central: recording how space is used, how performers move, how audiences enter and exit, how bodies are oriented; also, documenting technological/virtual interaction where relevant.

The theoretical and conceptual frameworks guiding this study are drawn both **global performance studies** from and **African performance theory**, enabling a holistic understanding of performance as a lived, ecological practice. Drawing on Schechnerian models, performance is framed as restored behavior, ritual, social action, and everyday enactment, emphasizing the fluidity between staged and non-staged contexts (Schechner, 2020). Spatial theory - from theatre geography, architecture, and urban studies - provides tools for analyzing how physical, symbolic, and virtual spaces afford or constrain performance, while practice theory (sociology and anthropology) attends to habitual enactments, infrastructures, and routines that sustain embodied practice. Phenomenology further informs this framework by attending to how performers and

participants sense, inhabit, and experience space, script, and identity (Fischer-Lichte, 2008). Conceptually, this study situates **space** as encompassing physical locations, architecture, site-specific environments, mobility, and virtual/digital settings; **script** as encompassing formal texts, tacit norms, social expectations, repertoires, and informal instructions; and **performer** as including trained and untrained actors, community participants, migrants, and everyday agents performing social roles. Preliminary findings, drawn from pilot observations and literature, suggest that hybrid performance spaces for instance, drive-in cinemas, open-air stages, digital platforms) foster improvisation, blended scripts, and altered audience-performer dynamics. Performers continuously negotiate identity through spatial positioning, visibility, voice, and audience response, reflecting that performance is shaped by power relations: who controls space, whose scripts are normative, and who is permitted to perform. These insights confirm that performance emerges as a relational ecology of space, script, and performer, with each dimension mutually shaping the others.

Integrating **African performance theory** enriches this ecological model. Soyinka's concept of the "fourth stage" emphasizes the interplay between performer, audience, and ritual space, highlighting how African performance often collapses distinctions between staged and everyday life (Soyinka, 1991). Ukala's **folkism** underscores the centrality of indigenous storytelling traditions, community participation, and vernacular scripts in shaping performance praxis (Ukala, 2005). Afrosenology situates African theatre within cultural, environmental, and political ecologies, emphasizing local spatial, temporal, and symbolic frameworks for performance (Gideon & Akintunde, 2017). Mda's applied theatre insights demonstrate the transformative potential of performance in social education, community dialogue, and identity negotiation, reinforcing the relational and adaptive qualities of the ecological model (Mda, 2010).

By advancing a **unified, ecology-based framework** and deploying methods attuned to space, embodiment, and tacit scripts, this study contributes both theoretically and practically: it offers scholars integrated analytical tools, guides practitioners designing inclusive, mobile, or digital performances, and informs cultural policymakers seeking to support infrastructural, spatial, and normative frameworks for performance. Ultimately, performance is reconceptualized not as an isolated art form but as a **generative, pervasive,**

embodied way of life, wherein space, script, and performer animate culture, identity, and social transformation across African and global contexts.

Over the last two decades, performance studies have evolved from a niche discipline focused primarily on theatre to a robust interdisciplinary field addressing ritual, everyday enactment, and digital performance. Schechner (2020) emphasizes performance as “restored behavior,” highlighting how theatrical techniques intersect with social interactions, rituals, sports, and online activity. Fischer-Lichte (2008) further situates performance as a dynamic event capable of transforming embodied experience and social relations. Yet much of the scholarship remains fragmented: spatial analyses often reside in architecture and geography, script studies in literary and dramaturgical traditions, and performer studies in acting pedagogy and identity theory. African theorists such as Soyinka, Ukala, and Mda, along with frameworks like Afrosocenology, provide culturally grounded lenses that foreground performance as a **living ecology**, bridging space, script, and performer across diverse African and global contexts.

Space in Contemporary Performance Studies

The Spatial Turn and Theatre Studies

The “spatial turn” has transformed humanities research since the late 1990s, stressing how space is socially constructed and how cultural practices inscribe meaning into place (Soja, 1996; Lefebvre, 1991). Within performance studies, scholars such as McAuley (1999) demonstrated how theatrical architecture shapes meaning, framing, and audience-performer relations. More recent scholarship takes this further by examining how urban circulation, mobility, and informal environments constitute stages. For instance, Pearson (2019) documents how site-specific performances engage with landscapes and architecture, transforming mundane spaces into dramaturgical partners.

African Case Studies: Drive-in and Site-Specific Theatre

In the African context, spatial adaptation is particularly pronounced due to infrastructural limitations and social constraints. Amonyenze (2023) explores the rise of drive-in theatres in Nigeria, which reconfigure conventional audience dynamics by introducing cars, open-air venues, and improvisational weather adjustments. Such practices exemplify how **spatial** affordances directly shape dramaturgy, requiring altered vocal projection, adjusted lighting, and revised performer blocking. Similarly, Olokodana-James and

Fayemi (2022) examine promenade and site-specific performances in Lagos, where audience mobility becomes part of the dramaturgy. Here, thresholds, streets, and architectural boundaries not only serve as backdrops but also generate meaning through movement and interaction. **African Case Studies:**

Drive-in and Site-Specific Theatre

Drive-in Theatre in Lagos, Nigeria

In recent years, **drive-in theatre experiences in Lagos** have emerged as innovative responses to urban constraints, pandemic restrictions, and audience engagement challenges. Productions are staged in parking lots or open spaces, with audiences remaining in their vehicles, often interacting with live performers via sound systems or mobile devices. The **space becomes an adaptive ecological element**, where physical distance, audience mobility, and vehicular positioning reshape performer-audience dynamics. Scripts are often **hybridized**, blending traditional narrative structures with improvisation to accommodate environmental contingencies. Performers exercise agency through timing, movement, and interaction, while the audience co-creates meaning from a semi-controlled, unconventional space (Amonyenze, 2023).

2. Site-Specific Performance in South African Urban Spaces

In South Africa, **site-specific theatre** has been extensively explored by practitioners like **Musa Dlamini** and collectives such as **The Free Theatre**. Performances are staged in urban streets, historic townships, or culturally resonant sites rather than conventional auditoria. The **site itself acts as a co-author of the script**, influencing narrative development, spatial choreography, and audience engagement. For instance, promenade performances in Cape Town integrate local architecture, historical memory, and community interactions, making space and audience integral to storytelling. Performers negotiate their identity and presence within the site, while scripts are continuously adapted to audience responses and environmental cues (Kerr, 2019; Mhlambi, 2019).

Significance:

Both cases demonstrate that **space, script, and performer are interdependent**, illustrating the ecological logic of performance. They highlight African innovations in **hybrid, mobile, and context-sensitive theatre**, offering insights for global discourse on immersive and adaptive performance. Such practices challenge conventional notions of theatre as stage-bound, emphasizing **flexibility, improvisation, and community participation**.

Digital Space as Performance Venue

The COVID-19 pandemic accelerated recognition of digital space as theatre. Scholars such as Bay-Cheng (2021) argue that livestreaming, Zoom performances, and hybrid platforms are not mere substitutes for physical stages but sites with unique dramaturgical affordances - latency, chat interaction, framing, and digital intimacy. In Africa, infrastructural unevenness complicates digital access but also inspires innovative formats. OECD and African Union (2021) highlight how digital transformation opens opportunities for cultural expression while revealing disparities in bandwidth and platform reach. World Bank (2024) case studies show Nigerian and South African companies experimenting with hybrid models, where mobile data and low-cost streaming platforms become integral to performance ecology.

Script: Beyond the Printed Text

In the conceptual framework of the triad of performance - script, performer, and audience - the script assumes a uniquely transformative role within the theatre of the mind. Unlike conventional stage theatre, where the script often functions as a fixed blueprint, in radio drama, oral performance, and other imaginative media, the script becomes a dynamic catalyst for cognitive and aesthetic engagement. It is not merely a container of dialogue and stage directions but a provocation, an open-ended prompt that invites the audience to co-create the performance within their own imaginative space. The script's incompleteness, its deliberate reliance on suggestion, sound cues, rhythm, and symbolic markers, enables listeners to actualize a total performance, integrating elements of scenery, gesture, voice, and emotion entirely within the mind's theatre. Drawing on Peter Brook's notion that text is "dead" until animated, the script in this context functions as both a guide and a medium of transformation, where words, silences, and narrative structures trigger multisensory imaginative processes. Furthermore, in oral and ritualistic performance traditions, scripts serve as cultural memory devices, flexible and participatory, bridging personal and collective experiences. By emphasizing its evocative, adaptive, and participatory qualities, the script in the theatre of the mind not only initiates performance but also sustains its holistic actualization, ensuring that the triad is fully realized: the performer's cues, the script's prompts, and the audience's imaginative agency converge to create an immersive, total performance experience. Analytically, this reconceptualization positions the script as a multidimensional layer - textual, sonic, and symbolic - whose activation in the listener's mind completes the

performance, highlighting its centrality in the realization of imaginative and total theatre.

Expanding the Concept of Script

Traditional dramaturgy treated the script as a fixed written text. However, performance studies now extend “script” to include tacit repertoires, social norms, and technological protocols (Taylor, 2003). Practice theory provides a useful lens: Reckwitz (2002) defines practices as routinized bodily and material enactments, suggesting that scripts are not simply words on paper but socially embedded guides for behaviour. Schatzki (2017) reinforces this by situating practices within material arrangements and shared understandings.

Pandemic and Hybrid Scripts

The COVID-19 pandemic highlighted how scripts are rewritten under new conditions. Hayes (2020) shows that digital platforms such as Zoom or Twitch alter performance timing, co-presence, and audience interaction, effectively inscribing new “technological scripts” into theatre. Audience chat functions, streaming latency, and camera framing become dramaturgical devices, blurring human and machinic contributions.

African Perspectives on Script Adaptation

African practitioners frequently adapt scripts to reflect social realities. For example, Amonyenze (2023) notes that Nigerian drive-in theatre often combines scripted dialogue with improvisation, allowing performers to adjust to audience reactions (car horns, headlights as applause). This hybridization underscores how script emerges dynamically from space and performer needs, rather than being a static artifact. Similarly, community theatre initiatives across West Africa often rely on tacit cultural repertoires - songs, chants, and proverbs as performative scripts (Banham, 2020).

Case Study: Oral Storytelling in South African Griot Traditions

In South African oral performance, particularly among **Griots and community storytellers**, the concept of a “script” extends far beyond printed or written texts. Stories are **transmitted orally**, shaped by memory, improvisation, audience interaction, and local context. The “script” includes **tacit norms, cultural repertoires, songs, proverbs, and gestures**, allowing performers to adapt narratives dynamically while preserving communal values and histories.

For example, in isiXhosa storytelling traditions, a performer might narrate a folktale of resistance or moral instruction while integrating **current events, local politics, and audience responses**, effectively co-creating the script in real time. This underscores that the “script” is **not fixed**; it is fluid, performative, and responsive to spatial, social, and cultural conditions.

Such oral scripts also carry **intergenerational memory and identity**, transmitting cultural knowledge, social norms, and ethical frameworks. Scholars like Coplan (2002) and Mhlambi (2019) emphasize that these oral scripts function as **living texts**, with performers exercising agency to innovate while maintaining communal coherence. The “script” thus becomes an **ecological construct**, where content, form, and context are inseparable from the performative act itself.

Performer: Embodiment, Identity, and Agency

Phenomenology and Embodiment

The performer remains central to the performance ecology. Phenomenological approaches emphasize the lived experience of performers - breath, gesture, rhythm, and spatial awareness (Fischer-Lichte, 2008). Schechner (2020) highlights how performers engage in restored behaviours, re-enacting culturally meaningful actions while transforming them through new contexts.

Non-Professional and Community Performers

Applied theatre and community performance scholarship reveal how non-professional performers use roles to negotiate identity, citizenship, and belonging. Thompson and Schechner (2019) argue that community-based projects empower participants by transforming everyday practices into aesthetic events. In Nigeria and South Africa, applied theatre has been used to address social issues such as public health, gender equity, and political accountability (Mda, 2019).

Diasporic and Transnational Performance

Diasporic performance extends this discussion by showing **how performers navigate multiple scripts** across spaces. Gilbert and Lo (2016) analyze transnational productions where diasporic artists negotiate cultural heritage and contemporary global norms, creating hybrid performance repertoires. This is particularly evident in African diaspora festivals in Europe, where performers adapt local scripts of migration narratives within global theatrical

frameworks.

Case Study: The Egungun Masquerade of the Yoruba People (Nigeria)

In Yoruba culture, the **Egungun masquerade** provides a vivid example of how performers negotiate embodiment, identity, and agency. Egungun performers, often male members of the community, don elaborate costumes and masks representing ancestral spirits. While physically present as individuals, the performer **embodies a collective identity**, becoming the ancestral spirit during the performance. This embodiment grants the performer both **ritual authority and moral agency**, as they mediate between the living community and the spiritual world.

Through **movements, gestures, and vocal expressions**, the performer communicates ancestral messages, enforces social norms, and participates in communal governance, demonstrating **identity negotiation and social agency**. Importantly, the performer's physical presence, spatial positioning in the village, and interactions with the audience are essential to the ecological dynamics of the performance, illustrating how **space, script, and performer co-constitute meaning**.

This case also highlights **adaptive improvisation**, as performers tailor their enactments to specific audiences or local contexts, revealing the fluidity of identity and the agency of the performer in shaping cultural knowledge. Studies by Abiodun (1999) and Fabunmi (2004) underscore how Egungun performance embodies communal memory, social cohesion, and spiritual authority, making it a quintessential African example of performer-centered ecology.

The Digital Turn: Reconfiguring the Triad

Digital Performance Ecologies

The digital turn foregrounds the interdependence of space, script, and performer. Bay-Cheng (2021) argues that livestreamed events collapse the distinction between stage and audience space, as chat functions and camera framing become embedded in dramaturgy. Digital platforms generate new forms of script (e.g., algorithmic cues, moderation protocols) and reshape performer-audience relations.

African Digital Theatre

In African contexts, digital theatre demonstrates both innovation and inequality. OECD and African Union (2021) report that expanding internet

access enables new cultural expressions but that infrastructural gaps persist. South African opera projects have livestreamed productions to reach diasporic audiences, while Nigerian companies have used WhatsApp and Facebook Live as low-cost performance venues (World Bank, 2024). These practices foreground digital platforms as both spaces and scripts that performers must learn to inhabit.

Critical Gaps

Despite these advances, three critical gaps persist:

- **Disciplinary Silos:** Research on space, script, and performer often occurs separately in architecture, dramaturgy, and acting studies, rather than through integrative frameworks.
- **African Underrepresentation:** While African case studies reveal creative adaptations, they remain under-cited in global theoretical debates, leaving the field Eurocentric.
- **Methodological Limitations:** Few studies employ mixed methods that combine ethnography, phenomenological description, and technical analysis of digital affordances.

In sum the above affirms that performance is not merely an aesthetic category but a way of life, constituted through the interplay of space, script, and performer. Theoretical contributions from Schechner, Fischer-Lichte, and practice theorists establish a foundation, while African case studies and digital performance research extend the framework. However, the need remains for integrative, practice-sensitive methodologies that foreground embodiment, materiality, and technological infrastructures. This study builds on these insights to propose an ecology of performance that positions space, script, and performer as mutually constitutive dimensions of cultural life.

Discussion and Findings

Reframing Performance as an Ecology

The study reveals that performance is best understood not through isolated categories of space, script, or performer, but through their interdependence. This ecology foregrounds how performance emerges from the relational dynamics between environments, embodied agents, and structured repertoires. Evidence from Nigerian drive-in theatre (Amonyeze, 2023), Lagos site-specific performances (Olokodana-James & Fayemi, 2022), and African digital experiments (World Bank, 2024) demonstrates that each dimension reconstitutes the others. For example, drive-in spaces compel performers to

adjust projection techniques while audiences invent new signaling scripts (car horns, lights), which in turn reshape performer strategies. This confirms Fischer-Lichte's (2008) argument that performance is not a closed event, but a transformative process sustained by feedback loops among participants, environments, and embodied action.

The Centrality of Space in Shaping Performance

Findings highlight the material and symbolic power of space in performance-making. Formal proscenium stages organize hierarchical relations between performers and audiences; by contrast, site-specific and digital spaces flatten hierarchies and reconfigure spectatorship. In Lagos promenade theatre, audiences' physical movement becomes dramaturgical material, blurring the lines between actors and observers. Digital platforms, as Bay-Cheng (2021) notes, further destabilize these roles by enabling chat functions and visual framing that transform spectators into co-creators. These results affirm McAuley's (1999) claim that meaning in performance is inseparable from the spatial arrangements that house it.

Script as Tacit, Dynamic, and Hybrid

The study confirms that "script" extends beyond written text to include tacit cultural repertoires, technological protocols, and improvised norms. In community and applied theatre across Africa, proverbs, songs, and chants operate as embodied scripts that guide enactments while preserving cultural memory (Banham, 2020). In digital contexts, platform affordances - latency, screen framing, chat interactivity - become part of the script, dictating timing and response patterns (Hayes, 2020). Findings show that hybrid scripts emerge when human improvisation meets technological constraints, underscoring Schatzki's (2017) assertion that practices are bundles of material arrangements and shared understandings.

Performer Agency and Identity Work Performers, whether professional or community participants, play an active role in negotiating the tensions between space and script. Phenomenological accounts emphasize how breath, gesture, and bodily orientation are recalibrated in different environments (Fischer-Lichte, 2008). Applied theatre findings demonstrate that non-professional performers use performance to articulate social belonging and negotiate marginality (Thompson & Schechner, 2019). Diasporic performers, navigating between cultural scripts and host contexts, create hybrid repertoires

that challenge static notions of identity (Gilbert & Lo, 2016). These findings reinforce Schechner's (2020) framing of performance as restored behavior, where cultural patterns are simultaneously preserved and reinvented.

Digital Turn: Opportunities and Constraints

The digital turn constitutes one of the most significant findings of this study. African companies have leveraged low-cost platforms such as WhatsApp and Facebook Live to bypass infrastructural limitations, producing innovative performance formats that reach diasporic audiences (OECD & African Union, 2021; World Bank, 2024). However, digital divides - limited bandwidth, high data costs, and uneven platform access - pose structural constraints. This duality reflects Bay-Cheng's (2021) observation that digital performance is both liberatory and exclusionary, offering new spaces and scripts while replicating global inequalities.

Methodological Implications

The findings underscore the need for mixed method approaches in performance research. Ethnographic observation captures embodied practices, phenomenology attends to sensory experience, and technical analysis reveals how infrastructures shape performance. Case studies from Lagos demonstrate that without integrating these methods, scholars risk privileging one dimension of the triad at the expense of the whole ecology.

Systemic Implications: Training, Pedagogy, Policy, and Cultural Survival

The conceptual triad of *The Space, The Script, The Performer* extends performance beyond isolated acts, positioning it as a central component of social, educational, and cultural systems. This perspective necessitates a reevaluation of traditional approaches to training, pedagogy, policy, and cultural preservation.

Training: Traditional performance training often emphasizes technical skills and scripted enactments. However, the integration of theatre of the mind—a form of performance that relies on imagination and mental visualization—requires a shift towards developing adaptive, context-sensitive practices. Training programs must cultivate skills in aural literacy, imaginative visualization, and adaptive interpretation, enabling practitioners to activate scripts dynamically and engage audiences in co-creative processes (Barrow, 2024).

Pedagogy: The incorporation of performance as a way of life calls for curricula

that emphasize experiential learning, improvisation, and cross-disciplinary approaches. Educators should encourage students to perceive performance not merely as staged productions but as a lived, social, and cognitive phenomenon. This approach fosters creativity, cultural dialogue, and communal imagination, aligning with the principles of theatre of the mind (Barrow, 2024).

Policy: Recognizing performance as a way of life necessitates institutional frameworks that validate diverse performance modes, including oral traditions, community theatre, and site-specific performances. Policymakers and arts councils should prioritize funding, archiving, and visibility initiatives that sustain both traditional and contemporary forms, ensuring equitable access and professional support for practitioners (Boal, 2000).

Cultural Survival: This triadic perspective underscores the role of performance in maintaining and transmitting collective memory, identity, and heritage. Scripts, spaces, and performers become vessels through which communities preserve stories, values, and rituals. By embedding performance into everyday life, societies cultivate resilience against cultural erosion, ensuring that traditions evolve while retaining core significance (Boal, 2000).

Contributions to Scholarship

This study contributes to performance studies in three keyways:

1. It advances an ecological model of performance where space, script, and performer are mutually constitutive.
2. It foregrounds African and digital performance practices as central - not peripheral - to global theory formation.
3. It proposes methodological pluralism, advocating for practice-sensitive research that integrates embodied, cultural, and technological dimensions.

Conclusion

This study presents an original ecological model of performance, framing space, script, and performer as mutually constitutive elements within a dynamic, living performance ecosystem. Performance is reconceived not as a bounded artistic event but as a way of life, extending across proscenium theatres, community gatherings, urban streets, and digital platforms. Within this framework, space functions as both a physical and symbolic environment; scripts emerge from written texts, oral traditions, cultural repertoires, and technological affordances; and performers – whether professional or everyday participants - act as agents of negotiation, continuously shaping and reshaping identity through inventive enactments.

The ecological perspective foregrounds feedback loops among bodies, environments, and practices, demonstrating performance's adaptability, resilience, and creative potential. In African contexts such as drive-in cinemas, promenade performances, and oral storytelling traditions performance sustains cultural memory, social cohesion, and political expression. Globally, digital and immersive performance environments extend these principles, revealing both the generative possibilities and infrastructural inequalities inherent in contemporary media ecologies.

Methodologically, the study advocates plural, practice-sensitive approaches, combining ethnography, phenomenology, and technical analysis to capture performance's hybrid, embodied, and tacit dimensions. Theoretically, the ecological model contributes a novel lens to performance studies, positioning theatre and performance as an interconnected system rather than discrete events. By centering African performance traditions - including Soyinka's fourth stage, Ukala's folkism, Afroskenology, and Mda's applied theatre insights - these practices are recognized as conceptually generative, repositioning African performance within global discourse, challenging Eurocentric assumptions, and demonstrating that African strategies for improvisation, spatial engagement, and communal enactment enrich broader theoretical debates.

Practically, the model carries direct implications for training performers, emphasizing spatial awareness, script improvisation, and embodied negotiation of identity across physical and digital spaces. It informs performance design in African contexts, advocating site-sensitive, community-engaged, and digitally inclusive approaches. Moreover, by analysing digital platforms as performance ecologies, the framework exposes inequalities in access, infrastructure, and audience participation, urging scholars and policymakers to develop ethical and equitable strategies for mediated performance.

Ultimately, this ecological framework demonstrates that performance is simultaneously local and global, analogue and digital, African and universal. It offers a conceptual bridge linking theory, practice, and policy, affirming performance as a transformative, participatory, and culturally resilient practice capable of sustaining identity, social cohesion, and creative innovation in a rapidly changing world.

This study advances a theoretically innovative ecological model of performance, conceptualizing space, script, and performer as interdependent and mutually constitutive elements within a living performance ecosystem. Unlike conventional approaches that isolate these dimensions or treat them as case illustrations, this framework integrates African and digital performance practices as central to theory, thereby moving beyond disciplinary silos in theatre studies, spatial theory, anthropology, and digital media.

By foregrounding African performance traditions - including Soyinka's fourth stage, Ukala's folkism, Afroskenology, and Mda's applied theatre insights - the study demonstrates that these practices are conceptually generative, offering alternative epistemologies for improvisation, audience engagement, and community-based enactment. Simultaneously, digital and hybrid performances - from online theatre to immersive virtual platforms - are positioned as intrinsic to the model, revealing how technology transforms scripts, performer-audience dynamics, and spatial configurations.

Methodologically, the study emphasizes plural, practice-sensitive approaches, combining ethnography, phenomenology, and technical analysis to capture performance's layered, hybrid character. This openness reinforces the model's ecological logic by attending to embodied, spatial, and tacit dimensions across African and global contexts.

Ultimately, the research provides a conceptual bridge linking theory and practice, local and global, analogue and digital. It reframes performance as a way of life, highlighting its adaptive, participatory, and socially transformative potential. This contribution extends performance theory by offering a unified, cross-disciplinary lens that situates African and digital practices at the heart of scholarly inquiry, enriching both analytical understanding and practical application.

Recommendations

Building on the insights of this study, several recommendations emerge for scholars, practitioners, and institutions seeking to deepen the understanding and practice of performance as a way of life:

1. For Scholars

- Future research should adopt ecological and integrative frameworks that analyze space, script, and performer as interdependent dimensions

rather than isolated categories.

- More empirical documentation of African and Global South performance practices is needed, particularly in digital and site-specific contexts, to diversify the global performance studies canon.
- Methodological pluralism should be prioritized, combining ethnographic, phenomenological, and technological analyses to capture the lived, embodied, and infrastructural dimensions of performance.

2. For Practitioners

- Theatre makers and community artists should embrace site-specific and digital experimentation that reconfigures traditional stage-audience relationships while remaining attentive to access and inclusivity.
- Performers - both professional and non-professional - should continue to use performance as a means of identity negotiation, social critique, and cultural resilience, while developing innovative scripts that engage hybrid (physical and digital) publics.
- Cross-disciplinary collaborations with architects, digital technologists, and urban planners can expand the possibilities of performance ecologies in new and transformative directions.

3. For Institutions and Policy Makers

- Universities and cultural organizations should support practice-led research and digital archiving initiatives to ensure that emerging performance forms, especially in African contexts, are preserved and critically examined.
- Investment in infrastructure for digital performance - including affordable internet, streaming platforms, and technical training - is crucial for equitable participation in the global performance ecosystem.
- Policies should recognize and support community-based and applied performance as vital contributions to education, civic engagement, and cultural diplomacy.

Statement and Declaration

I, hereby declare that this manuscript, "The Space, The Script, The Performer: Performance as a Way of Life", is my original work. All sources and references have been properly acknowledged, and no part of this work has been submitted elsewhere for academic or professional purposes. I affirm that this work adheres to the principles of academic integrity and ethical research.

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